Lesson 36 material: Choosing Evidence and Working from Sources

4.5: Choosing Appropriate Evidence

From *Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text* by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0). This section: CC BY-NC 4.0; authored, remixed or curated by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell (ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (OERI)).
Original page, with audio and online exercises:
https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Reading_Writing_Research_and_Reasoning%3A_An_Advanced_ESL_Text/04%3A_In
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Finding evidence that supports your point

Be sure that the evidence you use really does support the point you are trying to make. It is easy to choose evidence that seems to be about the same topic, but which is not actually directly connected to your point.

Let's look at an example:

Try this!

Suppose that you want to make this point:

Children of immigrants who continue to develop their fluency in their home languages while learning English have an economic advantage as adults.

You have found the article below that has information on your topic. Read the article and look for evidence to support your point.

Reading from an online magazine: Know more than one language? Don't give it up!

Rebecca Callahan, *University of Texas at Austin*

Speaking more than one language may confer significant benefits on the developing brain. Research has now shown that bilingual young adults not only fare better in the job market, but are also more likely to demonstrate empathy and problem-solving skills. The fact is that American adults are largely monolingual English speakers, even those who began life speaking more than one language. Based on the latest research, it might be time to rethink the emphasis on monolingualism in the US.

Speaking two languages has advantages

Over the past decade, my research has focused on the academic, social, and civic development of immigrant youth, specifically the ways in which schools shape how these students experience learning, friendships, and their communities. As a former elementary bilingual teacher, I saw how full proficiency in both languages offered students significant academic and social advantages. What was missing, however, was the link between my students' early social and academic edge, and their entry into the job market as young adults.

For all the research that supports childhood bilingualism, it is only recently that scholars have begun to understand bilingualism in adults' professional lives. Bilinguals show higher test scores, better problem-solving skills, sharper mental perceptions, and access to richer social networks. In addition, young bilinguals are able to draw support from mentors in their home language communities, and from the dominant culture. These young people benefit from the wisdom of the adage: the more adults who invest in a child, the stronger she will be. The bilingual child benefits from being raised by two or more villages!

Bilinguals more likely to get a job

Not only are bilingual young adults more likely to graduate high school and go to college, they are also more likely to get the job when they interview. Even when being bilingual is not a requirement, an interview study of California employers shows that employers prefer to both hire and retain bilinguals. Today, high-powered Fortune 500 companies hire bilingual and biliterate employees to serve as client liaisons.

Research links bilingualism to greater intellectual focus, as well as a delay in the onset of dementia symptoms. Frequent use of multiple languages is also linked to development of greater empathy. Yet, despite research evidence, 4 out of 5 American adults speak only English.

English-only movement discourages another language

This is true for even those adults who began life exposed to more than one language. In the process of growing up American, many potentially bilingual children of immigrant parents lose their home language to become English monolinguals. The powerful social and political forces behind the English-Only movement testify to the perceived threat of bilingualism. Every day, schools and districts across the nation succumb to external pressures and cut bilingual instruction.

Historically, research investigating bilingualism and the labor market has employed US Census measures that do not distinguish proficiency levels in the non-English language. Most national data-sets define bilingualism with very broad strokes that do not distinguish between a respondent who speaks only Spanish, one who speaks Spanish and a little English, and a third who is fully bilingual and biliterate. Failure to capture this heterogeneity obscures any clear relationship between bilingualism and the labor market. Only recently have NCES data begun to include measures of self-reported proficiency in the home language, while other, more immigrant-specific data-sets have begun to ask these questions.

Bilingualism related to higher earning

Of late, newer data and sharper analytical methods provide a far richer measure of bilingualism and individuals' ability to read and write in non-English languages. The ability to distinguish between oral proficiency in one or more languages and actual literacy skills in two or more has allowed researchers to identify an economic advantage to bilingualism – in terms of both higher occupational status and higher earnings in young adulthood. The new data-sets measure bilingualism in younger generations who enter a labor market defined not by geographic boundaries, but by instant access to information.

Relationship between bilingualism and intelligence

Beginning in the 1960s, linguists began to find a positive relationship between bilingualism and intelligence. Building on this work, researchers found that elementary-aged bilingual children outperform their monolingual peers on non-verbal problem-solving tasks. Then, in the late 1990s, research emerged showing that even when controlling on working memory, bilingual children display significantly greater attentional control to problem-solving tasks than monolingual children.

Currently, researchers have begun to use data-sets that include more sensitive measures of language proficiency to find that among children of immigrant parents, bilingual-biliterate young adults land in higher status jobs and earn more than their peers who have lost their home language. Not only have these now-monolingual young adults lost the cognitive resources bilingualism provides, but they are less likely to be employed full-time, and earn less than their peers.

Americans are beginning to grasp the cognitive, social and psychological benefits of knowing two languages.

Only 1 in 4 Americans can talk in another language

Historically notorious for their English monolingualism, a recent Gallup poll reports that in this nation of immigrants, only one in four American adults now reports being conversationally proficient in another language. However, much more needs to be done if our nation is to remain a global leader in the next century.

Schools' role in the maintenance and development of potential bilinguals' linguistic repertoires will be critical to this process. Whether through bilingual instruction or encouraging parents to develop their children's home language skills, what schools do will matter. Today's potential bilinguals will contribute more as adults if they successfully maintain their home language.

Educational research leaves little doubt that children of immigrant parents will learn English. Where we fail these children is in maintaining their greatest resource: their home language. It's something we should cherish, not eradicate. (Picture: The Conversation)

Rebecca Callahan, Associate Professor Bilingual/Bicultural Education, Cultural Studies in Education, *University of Texas at Austin*

This article is republished from The Conversation under a Creative Commons license. Read the original article.

Which quotation from this article provides the best support for the point you want to make?

1. "For all the research that supports childhood bilingualism, it is only recently that scholars have begun to understand bilingualism in adults' professional lives."
2. "Historically notorious for their English monolingualism, a recent Gallup poll reports that in this nation of immigrants, only one in four American adults now reports being conversationally proficient in another language."
3. "Not only are bilingual young adults more likely to graduate high school and go to college, they are also more likely to get the job when they interview. Even when being bilingual is not a requirement, an interview study of California employers shows that employers prefer to both hire and retain bilinguals."
4. "Research links bilingualism to greater intellectual focus, as well as a delay in the onset of dementia symptoms. Frequent use of multiple languages is also linked to development of greater empathy."

For suggested answer and comments, see 4.12: Integrating Evidence Answer Key

Licenses and Attributions

CC Licensed Content: Original

Authored by Annie Agard, Laney College. License: CC BY NC.

CC Licensed Content: Previously published

"Know more than one language? Don't give it up!" is republished from The Conversation and licensed under CC BY ND. Read the original article.

Links on the original page

- original article: https://theconversation.com/know-more-than-one-language-dont-give-it-up-37573

4.6: Working from Sources

From *Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text* by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0). This section: CC BY-NC 4.0; authored, remixed or curated by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell (ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (OERI)).
Original page, with audio and online exercises:
https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Reading_Writing_Research_and_Reasoning%3A_An_Advanced_ESL_Text/04%3A_In
Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

"They Say/I Say" approach to sources

When you write a research paper, you join a conversation about a topic that many other more expert writers have already studied and written about. Citing sources adds your ideas to that ongoing conversation. Sometimes you're citing a research finding that provides strong evidence for your point; at other times you're summarizing someone else's ideas in order to explain how your own opinion differs or to note how someone else's concept applies to a new situation. You first report what "they" say ("they" being published authors, prevalent ideas in society at large, or maybe participants in some kind of political or social debate). Then you respond by explaining what you think: Do you agree? Disagree? A little of both? Just like the participants in a real conversation (see Figure 4.6.1), you can learn and communicate the ideas of others while also adding your own voice to the discussion.

(Picture: four people stand together smiling and talking outside a meeting room)

Figure: "Symposium Indigenous Languages Today": Symposium on Indigenous Languages at the University of Pennsylvania's Quechua program. October 2019, by Quechua UPenn, is licensed under CC-BY-NC.

Balancing your ideas and source ideas

This "They Say/I Say" approach can help you find balance in your use of sources. Two mistakes that student writers can make are:

- Describing what sources say about a topic but then going on to state ideas or opinions that are not connected to the claims they have just summarized. For example, if you have research evidence that children who keep their home language perform better on cognitive tests, you can't jump to claiming that they have better high school graduation rates. You need more research evidence to support that second claim.
- At the other extreme, simply quoting, summarizing and paraphrasing what research sources say without including their own thoughts at all; a research paper is not just a report. It is a paper organized around your own thinking on the topic, supported by information that you get from your research.

How can you know when you're avoiding both of these extremes? Here are five common strategies. The strategies are in bold and are followed by an example:

- **Combine research findings from multiple sources to make a larger summary argument.** You might find that none of the sources you're working with specifically claim that immigrant students in your own city do not get enough support to continue building literacy in their home languages, but you can combine information from several sources that point in that direction. For example, you may find statistics from your city about how many students speak which languages at home, and compare those findings to the bilingual language programs in your local school district.
- **Combine research findings from multiple sources to make a claim about their implications.** For example, you might review papers that explore various factors affecting language loss in order to warn about the future consequences for children and communities.
- **Identify underlying areas of agreement.** For example, you might compare various students' experiences of learning a language in order to make generalizations about its effects.
- **Identify underlying areas of disagreement.** For example, you may find that the controversies about the effectiveness of bilingual education result from focusing on different student populations that have different needs.
- **Identify unanswered questions.** Perhaps you can review research about the effectiveness of dual-immersion and then argue for more in-depth research into why it is more successful for some student populations than for others.

When you cite sources that you agree with, you should choose quotes or paraphrases that serve as building blocks within your own argument.

Here are some more key principles for incorporating sources, principles which follow from the general point that academic writing is about entering an ongoing conversation.

Notice the context of the evidence in the original source

Have you ever had the maddening experience of arguing with someone who twisted your words to make it seem like you were saying something you weren't? Inexperienced writers sometimes misrepresent their sources when they quote very minor points from an article or even positions that the authors of an article disagree with, or which were just unimportant things mentioned in passing. This often happens when students approach their sources looking for information that matches their own opinion.

Notice this!

For example, let's say a writer wants to argue that being bilingual is actually bad for you. They might find this sentence in an article and include this quote in their paper:

"There were warnings that bilingual children would be confused by two languages, have lower intelligence, low self-esteem, behave in deviant ways, develop a split personality and even become schizophrenic."

But wait! Let's look at the whole paragraph from the article:

There were warnings that bilingual children would be confused by two languages, have lower intelligence, low self-esteem, behave in deviant ways, develop a split personality and even become schizophrenic. It is a view that persisted until very recently, discouraging many immigrant parents from using their own mother tongue to speak to their children, for instance. This is in spite of a 1962 experiment, ignored for decades, which showed that bilingual children did better than monolinguals in both verbal and non-verbal intelligence tests. However, research in the last decade by neurologists, psychologists, and linguists, using the latest brain-imaging tools, is revealing a swathe of cognitive benefits for bilinguals. It's all to do with how our ever-flexible minds learn to multitask.

The author of the article is clearly against the idea and goes on to refute it. She only put it in her article to fight back against it. So if a student writer uses the first quote out of context, it looks like they didn't notice that they are using evidence that was already proven wrong by their source.

Use sources efficiently

You can quote or paraphrase whole sentences or just phrases from another text. Less commonly, you can also quote long passages of more than one sentence using block quotes; this means that you indent the quote two tabs and omit the quotation marks. Most quotes should be short (key terms, phrases, parts of sentences, or single sentences), and the longer quotes (whole sentences and passages) should have a good reason to be there.

Every bit of every quote should feel necessary to the paper. Too many long quotes usually mean that your own argument is undeveloped. You can also use paraphrasing and summarizing. These are more difficult when you are not writing in your first language, but are often more appropriate to use than direct quoting. In fact, a good college research paper typically includes few direct quotes. Student writers may avoid paraphrasing because it is more difficult. Also, because many writers are afraid of plagiarizing, sticking to direct quotes seems safer. However, it is worth your time to work at building your paraphrasing skills because it is often a paraphrase that fits most smoothly into your own writing.

Licenses and Attributions

CC Licensed Content: Original

Authored by Anne Agard, Laney College and Gabriel Winer, Berkeley City College. License: CC BY NC.

CC Licensed Content: Previously Published

Instructions on working with sources adapted from Athena Kashyap & Erika Dyquisto, Working With Sources I, licensed CC BY SA.

Sample sentences are from "Why Being Bilingual Helps Keep Your Brain Fit" published on Mosaic and licensed under CC BY 4.0.